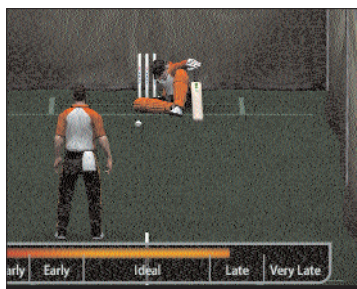




Bowler delivers a ball; I hit it; he's already turning as I play my shot...



Timing is everything, especially when fending off a bouncer—ouch!



Caught and bowled before the batsman can take three steps...



Standing outside the line—out. Plumb in front—not out. Match fixing?



A replay of a run out is pretty similar to what you see on TV—good!



Dada gone for a duck! Told you it's a little too real, didn't we?

The Game: Average

Pakistan wins the toss and elects to bat—typical! Afridi tries to hit Zaheer Khan for a six, first ball up, and holes out in the deep—also expected. Then Inzamam smashes a six, and I start bowling length and short out-swingers to end the over. Ajit Agarkar gets smashed for a six as well, and then next ball clean bowls Inzi. It's the same throughout... bowl a loose delivery, or try anything new, and you're smashed for a six—even by tailenders! Every now and then, a bowler gets a "power-up", which lets him bowl a "special delivery," but nothing seems special about it!

Attention to Detail: Poor

I should also mention that EA has done a terrible job with the player's faces. No Indian player looks anything like the real deal. And will someone please send the folks at EA a picture of Sachin Tendulkar! The master blaster is depicted as a skinny, tall, dark-skinned player with a moustache!

Commentary: Hilarious

The commentary from Richie Benaud is boring at best, with stupid comments about why players wear coloured clothes for day and night matches. Then I start to notice the bugs... he often mentions that India needs to pick up the run rate, but it is Pakistan that's batting! Then I bring Tendulkar on to bowl, his

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first four balls are smashed for sixes, and Benaud says something like, "This is turning out to be a good over for India." While I contemplate on whether to laugh or cry, Pakistan are all out for 92.

Batting: Impossible

Now comes the dreaded time, batting.

At least Shoaib Akhtar looks like his real self, and his bowling is just as lethal. The score goes from 1 for 1, to 2 for 2, then 3 for

three, and India are soon bowled out for 14. I knew I should have opted to be Pakistan!

Only once did a smile appear on my face during the torturous 10 overs of batting, and that was when "Dada" got out for a duck!

Overall: 5/10

Overall, this game loses out on three factors: it's too tough to play, the graphics (especially character depictions) are pathetic, and the AI (fielding) is too powerful to be enjoyable!

It does win in terms of replay-ability, and other options such as creating your own player, playing different tournaments, playing domestic cricket, training in the nets, etc.

If you have money to blow, are a sucker for punishment and love to have the stuffing beaten out of you in games... play *DOOM 3* in Nightmare mode without cheats. EA Sports' *Cricket 2005* is strictly for cricket fanatics in India, and since there are millions of them, this game might do pretty well. The rest are advised to check out the demo first.

robert_smith@thinkdigit.com

Cricket 2005

Publisher EA Sports, Price Rs 999

Web site www.eaplay.com

System requirements Windows 98/SE/Me/2000/XP, 700 MHz CPU,

DirectX 9.0 compatible card, 256 MB RAM, IE6

Distributor Gayatri Impex

TechCritique

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